

Infra visions in manifestos

Elections have never been won or lost solely based on voters reading manifestos! But it is a fact that think-tanks and policy cells of various political parties spend considerable time drafting their manifestos and getting them cleared by their political bosses. The recent skirmish between the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) and the Congress party on certain specific items in the Congress manifesto confirms that manifestos have not completely lost their relevance.

So, here are some of the key infrastructure highlights from the manifestos of the BJP, Congress, CPI(M), DMK and TMC.

It is not surprising that the railways has taken centre stage in the manifesto of the BJP, lending credence to the increasing belief that the railways is set to be of greater significance in the next five years than roads. The BJP talks of constructing 5,000-plus km of new tracks every year, expanding the Kavach safety systems, re-developing over 130-plus railway stations, and introducing rapid rail inter-city train services like Delhi-Meerut. Initiating metro rail projects in 20-plus cities is high on the agenda, as is the propagation of user-friendly super apps. The Congress party's only contribution to the railway discussion is insisting on safety and modernising outdated infrastructure. In the safety aspect, it is joined by the DMK and TMC. Rather surprisingly, both the DMK and TMC want the re-introduction of a separate Rail Budget like old times!

The BJP appears to have no fresh ideas on roads other than building 15,000 km of access-controlled highways. There is no mention of the much-anticipated GPS-based tolling system. The makings of a more investor-friendly Build Operate Transfer format also does not find mention. The Congress wants a new formula for calculating road tolls, though the specifics are left unsaid. Road safety is only alluded to in the BJP manifesto.

In terms of ports, the BJP manifesto restricts itself to doubling the share of inland water transport and the CPI(M) wants withdrawal of the Landlord Model of public sector port development. It is the

TMC manifesto that mentions the need for having coastal economic zones.

Water is clearly the next big item after railways. The manifestos of the BJP, Congress, and TMC all prioritise providing access to clean and safe drinking water. The DMK and Congress manifestos specifically mention the establishment of desalination plants in all coastal areas. The BJP and Congress manifestos focus on addressing water quality, effluent management, and river revitalisation. The CPI(M) proposes reformulating the National Water Policy to treat water as a scarce public good and emphasises protection of rivers, expansion of water bodies, and increased groundwater recharging.

In aviation, the BJP mentions expanding international airports and implementing the Amrit Kaal Civil Aviation Master Plan to upgrade airports into regional hubs. The CPI(M) advocates public-sector control over airport construction, operation, and maintenance.

Transport and logistics feature prominently in party manifestos, reflecting diverse strategies for their development. The BJP's manifesto talks about expanding the fleet of e-Buses, strengthening waterways, and urges the creation of unified metropolitan transport systems to integrate multi-modal transport facilities. The Congress manifesto sup-

ports the idea of integrated multi-modal public transport in urban areas. All this should logically lead to the implementation of a Unified Metropolitan Transport Authority (UMTA) for Indian cities, which is still awaiting real implementation after its first policy announcement in 2006. The TMC aims to expand Kolkata Metro into the suburbs. Only the BJP and DMK address electric vehicles (EVs) in their manifestos, where they primarily focus on establishing nationwide charging infrastructure and increasing subsidies for EVs.

Agricultural infrastructure emerges as a pivotal battleground for parties vying for the rural vote, with the manifestos of the BJP, Congress, DMK, CPI(M), and TMC all laying out a range of strategies. The BJP underscores integrated planning via initiatives like the Krishi Infrastructure Mission, focusing on irrigation



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expansion and storage capacity. The DMK emphasises river-interlinking projects and cold storage facilities. The TMC mentions cold-chain infrastructure.

In the realm of housing infrastructure, the BJP vows to expand the PM Awas Yojana and strengthen the RERA Act. The Congress champions the Right to Homestead Act.

In the sphere of power sector policies, the BJP, TMC, and DMK all converge on promoting renewable energy. The Congress presents a Green New Deal Investment Programme, aiming to boost renewable energy adoption and generating green jobs. Notably, it proposes incentivising panchayats to establish solar grids for communal use, aligning with its focus on grassroots empowerment. The BJP vows to expand green hydrogen production, envisioning India as a hydrogen hub.

At the policy level, the BJP's manifesto emphasises the need for a robust resource mobilisation strategy, blending public and private investment across sectors like railways, airports, and digital infrastructure. The manifesto aims to attract private investment by simplifying regulations for private investment in infrastructure. The Congress also prioritises reviving public-private partnerships (PPPs) whilst expressing concern over the effectiveness of the current PPP model. If one were to commend consistency across past and current manifestos, the prize would surely go to the CPI(M) for never wavering from its espousal that all infrastructure development, maintenance, and operations should be by the public sector!

A key missing area across all the manifestos relates to the concern about urban infrastructure. Whether it is the development of Smart Cities or raising municipal bonds to fund India's booming city infrastructure requirements, the political will appears to be absent.

Overall, it must be said, with a certain amount of disappointment, that the manifestos do not have much to offer by way of inspirational programmes and ideas for India's infrastructure development.

But maybe one should not expect too much from manifestos.

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